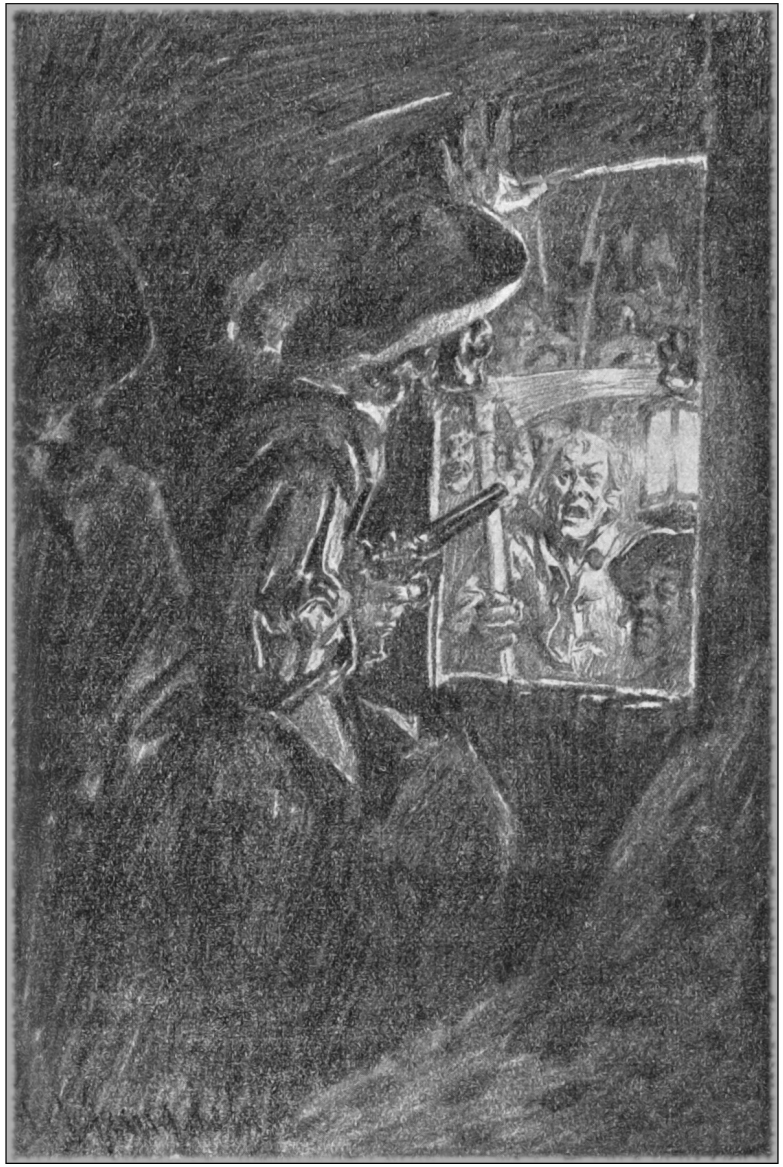

'Let them pass; they are friends.'

'What is to be done?' said Porthos.

'*Pardieu!* pass,' replied D'Artagnan.

'But *how?*' asked Mazarin.

'Through or over; coachman, gallop on.'

The coachman raised his whip.

'Not a step further,' said the man, who appeared to be the captain, 'or I will hamstring your horses.'

'*Peste!*' said Porthos, 'it would be a pity; animals which cost me a hundred pistoles each.'

'I will pay you two hundred for them,' said Mazarin.

'Yes, but when once they are hamstrung, our necks will be strung next.'

'If one of them comes to my side,' asked Porthos, 'must I kill him?'

'Yes, by a blow of your fist, if you can; we will not fire but at the last extremity.'

'I can do it,' said Porthos.

'Come and open, then!' cried D'Artagnan to the man with the scythe, taking one of the pistols up by the muzzle and preparing to strike with the handle. And as the man approached, D'Artagnan, in order to have more freedom for his actions, leaned half out of the door; his eyes were fixed upon those of the mendicant, which were lighted up by a lantern. Without doubt he recognised D'Artagnan, for he became deadly pale; doubtless the musketeer knew him, for his hair stood up on his head.

'Monsieur d'Artagnan!' he cried, falling back a step; 'it is Monsieur d'Artagnan! *let him pass*.'

D'Artagnan was perhaps about to reply, when a blow, similar to that of a mallet falling on the head of an ox, was heard. The noise was caused by Porthos, who had just knocked down his man.

D'Artagnan turned around and saw the unfortunate man upon his back about four paces off.

''Sdeath!' cried he to the coachman. 'Spur your horses! whip! get on!'

The coachman bestowed a heavy blow of the whip upon his horses; the noble animals bounded forward; then cries of men who were knocked down were heard; then a double concussion was felt, and two of the wheels seemed to pass over a round and flexible body. There was a moment's silence, then the carriage cleared the gate.

'To Cours la Reine!' cried D'Artagnan to the coachman; then turning to Mazarin he said, 'Now, my lord, you can say five *paters* and five *aves*, in thanks to Heaven for your deliverance. You are safe—you are free.'

Mazarin replied only by a groan; he could not believe in such a miracle. Five minutes later the carriage stopped, having reached Cours la Reine.

'Is my lord pleased with his escort?' asked D'Artagnan.

'Enchanted, monsieur,' said Mazarin, venturing his head out of one of the windows; 'and now do as much for the queen.'

'It will not be so difficult,' replied D'Artagnan, springing to the ground. 'Monsieur du Vallon, I commend his eminence to your care.'

'Be quite at ease,' said Porthos, holding out his hand, which D'Artagnan took and shook in his.

'Oh!' cried Porthos, as if in pain.

D'Artagnan looked with surprise at his friend.

'What is the matter, then?' he asked.

'I think I have sprained my wrist,' said Porthos.

'The devil! why, you strike like a blind or a deaf man.'

'It was necessary; my man was going to fire a pistol at me; but you—how did you get rid of yours?'

'Oh, mine,' replied D'Artagnan, 'was not a man.'

'What was it then?'

'It was an apparition.'

'And— '

'I charmed it away.'

Without further explanation D'Artagnan took the pistols which were upon the front seat, placed them in his belt, wrapped himself in his cloak, and not wishing to enter by the same gate as that through which they had left, he took his way toward the Richelieu gate.

The chief approached, and it was indeed Planchet; D'Artagnan had recognised the voice of his old servant.

'How, sir!' said Planchet, 'is it you?'

'Eh! *mon Dieu!* yes, my good friend, this worthy Porthos has just received a sword wound and I am taking him to his country house at Saint Cloud.'

'Oh! really,' said Planchet.

'Porthos,' said D'Artagnan, 'if you can still speak, say a word, my dear Porthos, to this good Planchet.'

'Planchet, my friend,' said Porthos, in a melancholy voice, 'I am very ill; should you meet a doctor you will do me a favor by sending him to me.'

'Oh! good Heaven,' said Planchet, 'what a misfortune! and how did it happen?'

'I will tell you all about it,' replied Mousqueton.

Porthos uttered a deep groan.

'Make way for us, Planchet,' said D'Artagnan in a whisper to him, 'or he will not arrive alive; the lungs are attacked, my friend.'

Planchet shook his head with the air of a man who says, 'In that case things look ill.' Then he exclaimed, turning to his men:

'Let them pass; they are friends.'

The carriage resumed its course, and Mazarin, who had held his breath, ventured to breathe again.

'*Bricconi!*' muttered he.

A few steps in advance of the gate of Saint Honoré they met a third troop; this latter party was composed of ill-looking fellows, who resembled bandits more than anything else; they were the men of the beggar of Saint Eustache.

'Attention, Porthos!' cried D'Artagnan.

Porthos placed his hand on the pistols.

'What is it?' asked Mazarin.

'My lord, I think we are in bad company.'

A man advanced to the door with a kind of scythe in his hand. '*Qui vive?*' he asked.

'Eh, rascal!' said D'Artagnan, 'do you not recognise his highness the prince's carriage?'

'Prince or not,' said the man, 'open. We are here to guard the gate, and no one whom we do not know shall pass.'

'Mount, my lord,' said D'Artagnan to Mazarin, who sprang into the carriage without waiting for a second bidding. D'Artagnan followed him, and Mousqueton, having closed the door, mounted behind the carriage with many groans. He had made some difficulties about going, under pretext that he still suffered from his wound, but D'Artagnan had said to him:

'Remain if you like, my dear Monsieur Mouston, but I warn you that Paris will be burnt down to-night;' upon which Mousqueton had declared, without asking anything further, that he was ready to follow his master and Monsieur d'Artagnan to the end of the world.

The carriage started at a measured pace, without betraying by the slightest sign that it contained people in a hurry. The cardinal wiped his forehead with his handkerchief and looked around him. On his left was Porthos, whilst D'Artagnan was on his right; each guarded a door and served as a rampart to him on either side. Before him, on the front seat, lay two pairs of pistols—one in front of Porthos and the other of D'Artagnan. About a hundred paces from the Palais Royal a patrol stopped the carriage.

'Who goes?' asked the captain.

'Mazarin!' replied D'Artagnan, bursting into a laugh. The cardinal's hair stood on end. But the joke appeared an excellent one to the citizens, who, seeing the conveyance without escort and unarmed, would never have believed in the possibility of so great an imprudence.

'A good journey to ye,' they cried, allowing it to pass.

'Hem!' said D'Artagnan, 'what does my lord think of that reply?'

'Man of talent!' cried Mazarin.

'In truth,' said Porthos, 'I understand; but now— '

About the middle of the Rue des Petits Champs they were stopped by a second patrol.

'Who goes there?' inquired the captain of the patrol.

'Keep back, my lord,' said D'Artagnan. And Mazarin buried himself so far behind the two friends that he disappeared, completely hidden between them.

'Who goes there?' cried the same voice, impatiently whilst D'Artagnan perceived that they had rushed to the horses' heads. But putting his head out of the carriage:

'Eh! Planchet,' said he.

Chapter LII

The Carriage of Monsieur le Coadjuteur

INSTEAD of returning, then, by the Saint Honoré gate, D'Artagnan, who had time before him, walked around and re-entered by the Porte Richelieu. He was approached to be examined, and when it was discovered by his plumed hat and his laced coat, that he was an officer of the musketeers, he was surrounded, with the intention of making him cry, 'Down with Mazarin!' The demonstration did not fail to make him uneasy at first; but when he discovered what it meant, he shouted it in such a voice that even the most exacting were satisfied. He walked down the Rue Richelieu, meditating how he should carry off the queen in her turn, for to take her in a carriage bearing the arms of France was not to be thought of, when he perceived an equipage standing at the door of the hotel belonging to Madame de Guéménée.

He was struck by a sudden idea.

'Ah, *pardieu!*' he exclaimed; 'that would be fair play.'

And approaching the carriage, he examined the arms on the panels and the livery of the coachman on his box. This scrutiny was so much the more easy, the coachman being sound asleep.

'It is, in truth, monsieur le coadjuteur's carriage,' said D'Artagnan; 'upon my honour I begin to think that Heaven favors us.'

He mounted noiselessly into the chariot and pulled the silk cord which was attached to the coachman's little finger.

'To the Palais Royal,' he called out.

The coachman awoke with a start and drove off in the direction he was desired, never doubting but that the order had come from his master. The porter at the palace was about to close the gates, but seeing such a handsome equipage he fancied that it was some visit of importance and the carriage was allowed to pass and to stop beneath the porch. It was then only the coachman perceived the grooms were not behind the vehicle; he fancied monsieur le coadjuteur had sent them back, and without dropping the reins he sprang from his box to open the door. D'Artagnan, in his turn, sprang to the ground, and just at the moment when the coachman, alarmed at not seeing his master, fell back a step, he seized him by his collar with the left, whilst with the right hand he placed the muzzle of a pistol at his breast.

'Pronounce one single word,' muttered D'Artagnan, 'and you are a dead man.'

The coachman perceived at once, by the expression of the man who thus addressed him, that he had fallen into a trap, and he remained with his mouth wide open and his eyes portentously staring.

Two musketeers were pacing the court, to whom D'Artagnan called by their names.

'Monsieur de Bellière,' said he to one of them, 'do me the favor to take the reins from the hands of this worthy man, mount upon the box and drive to the door of the private stair, and wait for me there; it is an affair of importance on the service of the king.'

The musketeer, who knew that his lieutenant was incapable of jesting with regard to the service, obeyed without a word, although he thought the order strange. Then turning toward the second musketeer, D'Artagnan said:

'Monsieur du Verger, help me to place this man in a place of safety.'

The musketeer, thinking that his lieutenant had just arrested some prince in disguise, bowed, and drawing his sword, signified that he was ready. D'Artagnan mounted the staircase, followed by his prisoner, who in his turn was followed by the soldier, and entered Mazarin's ante-room. Bernouin was waiting there, impatient for news of his master.

'Well, sir?' he said.

'Everything goes on capitally, my dear Monsieur Bernouin, but here is a man whom I must beg you to put in a safe place.'

'Where, then, sir?'

D'Artagnan was not less exact to his appointment and at half-past nine o'clock he entered the ante-room.

He found the cardinal dressed as an officer, and he looked very well in that costume, which, as we have already said, he wore elegantly; only he was very pale and trembled slightly.

'Quite alone?' he asked.

'Yes, my lord.'

'And that worthy Monsieur du Vallon, are we not to enjoy his society?'

'Certainly, my lord; he is waiting in his carriage at the gate of the garden of the Palais Royal.'

'And we start in his carriage, then?'

'Yes, my lord.'

'And with us no other escort but you two?'

'Is it not enough? One of us would suffice.'

'Really, my dear Monsieur d'Artagnan,' said the cardinal, 'your coolness startles me.'

'I should have thought, on the contrary, that it ought to have inspired you with confidence.'

'And Bernouin—do I not take him with me?'

'There is no room for him, he will rejoin your eminence.'

'Let us go,' said Mazarin, 'since everything must be done as you wish.'

'My lord, there is time to draw back,' said D'Artagnan, 'and your eminence is perfectly free.'

'Not at all, not at all,' said Mazarin; 'let us be off.'

And so they descended the private stair, Mazarin leaning on the arm of D'Artagnan a hand the musketeer felt trembling. At last, after crossing the courts of the Palais Royal, where there still remained some of the conveyances of late guests, they entered the garden and reached the little gate. Mazarin attempted to open it by a key which he took from his pocket, but with such shaking fingers that he could not find the keyhole.

'Give it to me,' said D'Artagnan, who when the gate was open deposited the key in his pocket, reckoning upon returning by that gate.

The steps were already down and the door open. Mousqueton stood at the door and Porthos was inside the carriage.

Mazarin hesitated for one instant, but D'Artagnan was firm.

'Come, then,' said the minister; 'I will conduct you to her, but remember, not one word of our conversation.'

'What has passed between us concerns ourselves alone, my lord,' replied D'Artagnan.

'Swear to be mute.'

'I never swear, my lord, I say yes or no; and, as I am a gentleman, I keep my word.'

'Come, then, I see that I must trust unreservedly to you.'

'Believe me, my lord, it will be your best plan.'

'Come,' said Mazarin, conducting D'Artagnan into the queen's oratory and desiring him to wait there. He did not wait long, for in five minutes the queen entered in full gala costume. Thus dressed she scarcely appeared thirty-five years of age. She was still exceedingly handsome.

'It is you, Monsieur D'Artagnan,' she said, smiling graciously; 'I thank you for having insisted on seeing me.'

'I ought to ask your majesty's pardon, but I wished to receive your commands from your own mouth.'

'Do you accept the commission which I have intrusted to you?'

'With gratitude.'

'Very well, be here at midnight.'

'I will not fail.'

'Monsieur d'Artagnan,' continued the queen, 'I know your disinterestedness too well to speak of my own gratitude at such a moment, but I swear to you that I shall not forget this second service as I forgot the first.'

'Your majesty is free to forget or to remember, as it pleases you; and I know not what you mean,' said D'Artagnan, bowing.

'Go, sir,' said the queen, with her most bewitching smile, 'go and return at midnight.'

And D'Artagnan retired, but as he passed out he glanced at the curtain through which the queen had entered and at the bottom of the tapestry he remarked the tip of a velvet slipper.

'Good,' thought he; 'Mazarin has been listening to discover whether I betrayed him. In truth, that Italian puppet does not deserve the services of an honest man.'

'Where you like, provided that the place which you shall choose has iron shutters secured by padlocks and a door that can be locked.'

'We have that, sir,' replied Bernouin; and the poor coachman was conducted to a closet, the windows of which were barred and which looked very much like a prison.

'And now, my good friend,' said D'Artagnan to him, 'I must invite you to deprive yourself, for my sake, of your hat and cloak.'

The coachman, as we can well understand, made no resistance; in fact, he was so astonished at what had happened to him that he stammered and reeled like a drunken man; D'Artagnan deposited his clothes under the arm of one of the valets.

'And now, Monsieur du Verger,' he said, 'shut yourself up with this man until Monsieur Bernouin returns to open the door. The duty will be tolerably long and not very amusing, I know; but,' added he, seriously, 'you understand, it is on the king's service.'

'At your command, lieutenant,' replied the musketeer, who saw the business was a serious one.

'By-the-bye,' continued D'Artagnan, 'should this man attempt to fly or to call out, pass your sword through his body.'

The musketeer signified by a nod that these commands should be obeyed to the letter, and D'Artagnan went out, followed by Bernouin. Midnight struck.

'Lead me into the queen's oratory,' said D'Artagnan, 'announce to her I am here, and put this parcel, with a well-loaded musket, under the seat of the carriage which is waiting at the foot of the private stair.'

Bernouin conducted D'Artagnan to the oratory, where he sat down pensively. Everything had gone on as usual at the Palais Royal. As we said before, by ten o'clock almost all the guests had dispersed; those who were to fly with the court had the word of command and they were each severally desired to be from twelve o'clock to one at Cours la Reine.

At ten o'clock Anne of Austria had entered the king's room. Monsieur had just retired, and the youthful Louis, remaining the last, was amusing himself by placing some lead soldiers in a line of battle, a game which delighted him much. Two royal pages were playing with him.

'Laporte,' said the queen, 'it is time for his majesty to go to bed.'

The king asked to remain up, having, he said, no wish to sleep; but the queen was firm.

'Are you not going to-morrow morning at six o'clock, Louis, to bathe at Conflans? I think you wished to do so of your own accord?'

'You are right, madame,' said the king, 'and I am ready to retire to my room when you have kissed me. Laporte, give the light to Monsieur the Chevalier de Coislin.'

The queen touched with her lips the white, smooth brow the royal child presented to her with a gravity which already partook of etiquette.

'Go to sleep soon, Louis,' said the queen, 'for you must be awakened very early.'

'I will do my best to obey you, madame,' said the youthful king, 'but I have no inclination to sleep.'

'Laporte,' said Anne of Austria, in an undertone, 'find some very dull book to read to his majesty, but do not undress yourself.'

The king went out, accompanied by the Chevalier de Coislin, bearing the candlestick, and then the queen returned to her own apartment. Her ladies—that is to say Madame de Bregy, Mademoiselle de Beaumont, Madame de Motteville, and Socratine, her sister, so called on account of her sense—had just brought into her dressing-room the remains of the dinner, on which, according to her usual custom, she supped. The queen then gave her orders, spoke of a banquet which the Marquis de Villequier was to give to her on the day after the morrow, indicated the persons she would admit to the honour of partaking of it, announced another visit on the following day to Val-de-Grace, where she intended to pay her devotions, and gave her commands to her senior valet to accompany her. When the ladies had finished their supper the queen feigned extreme fatigue and passed into her bedroom. Madame de Motteville, who was on especial duty that evening, followed to aid and undress her. The queen then began to read, and after conversing with her affectionately for a few minutes, dismissed her.

It was at this moment D'Artagnan entered the courtyard of the palace, in the coadjutor's carriage, and a few seconds later the carriages of the ladies-in-waiting drove out and the gates were shut after them.

A few minutes after twelve o'clock Bernouin knocked at the queen's bedroom door, having come by the cardinal's secret corridor. Anne of Austria

'I valued it much,' said Mazarin, giving a last look at it; 'nevertheless, I give it to you with great pleasure.'

'And I, my lord,' said D'Artagnan, 'accept it as it is given. Come, let us speak of your little affairs. You wish to leave before everybody and at what hour?'

'At ten o'clock.'

'And the queen, at what time is it her wish to start?'

'At midnight.'

'Then it is possible. I can get you out of Paris and leave you beyond the *barrière*, and can return for her.'

'Capital; but how will you get me out of Paris?'

'Oh! as to that, you must leave it to me.'

'I give you absolute power, therefore; take as large an escort as you like.'

D'Artagnan shook his head.

'It seems to me, however,' said Mazarin, 'the safest method.'

'Yes, for you, my lord, but not for the queen; you must leave it to me and give me the entire direction of the undertaking.'

'Nevertheless— '

'Or find some one else,' continued D'Artagnan, turning his back.

'Oh!' muttered Mazarin, 'I do believe he is going off with the diamond! M. d'Artagnan, my dear M. d'Artagnan,' he called out in a coaxing voice, 'will you answer for everything?'

'I will answer for *nothing*. I will do my best.'

'Well, then, let us go—I must trust to you.'

'It is very fortunate,' said D'Artagnan to himself.

'You will be here at half-past nine.'

'And I shall find your eminence ready?'

'Certainly, quite ready.'

'Well, then, it is a settled thing; and now, my lord, will you obtain for me an audience with the queen?'

'For what purpose?'

'I wish to receive her majesty's commands from her own lips.'

'She desired me to give them to you.'

'She may have forgotten something.'

'You really wish to see her?'

'It is indispensable, my lord.'

'Yes,' continued the cardinal. 'I have my plan. With the queen I double her risk; after the queen her departure would double mine; then, the court once safe, I might be forgotten. The great are often ungrateful.'

'Very true,' said D'Artagnan, fixing his eyes, in spite of himself, on the queen's diamond, which Mazarin wore on his finger. Mazarin followed the direction of his eyes and gently turned the hoop of the ring inside.

'I wish,' he said, with his cunning smile, 'to prevent them from being ungrateful to me.'

'It is but Christian charity,' replied D'Artagnan, 'not to lead one's neighbors into temptation.'

'It is exactly for that reason,' said Mazarin, 'that I wish to start *before* them.'

D'Artagnan smiled—he was just the man to understand the astute Italian. Mazarin saw the smile and profited by the moment.

'You will begin, therefore, by taking me first out of Paris, will you not, my dear M. d'Artagnan?'

'A difficult commission, my lord,' replied D'Artagnan, resuming his serious manner.

'But,' said Mazarin, 'you did not make so many difficulties with regard to the king and queen.'

'The king and the queen are my king and queen,' replied the musketeer, 'my life is theirs and I must give it for them. If they ask it what have I to say?'

'That is true,' murmured Mazarin, in a low tone, 'but as thy life is not mine I suppose I must buy it, must I not?' and sighing deeply he began to turn the hoop of his ring outside again. D'Artagnan smiled. These two men met at one point and that was, cunning; had they been actuated equally by courage, the one would have done great things for the other.

'But, also,' said Mazarin, 'you must understand that if I ask this service from you it is with the intention of being grateful.'

'Is it still only an intention, your eminence?' asked D'Artagnan.

'Stay,' said Mazarin, drawing the ring from his finger, 'my dear D'Artagnan, there is a diamond which belonged to you formerly, it is but just it should return to you; take it, I pray.'

D'Artagnan spared Mazarin the trouble of insisting, and after looking to see if the stone was the same and assuring himself of the purity of its water, he took it and passed it on his finger with indescribable pleasure.

opened the door to him herself. She was dressed, that is to say, in *dishabille*, wrapped in a long, warm dressing-gown.

'It is you, Bernouin,' she said. 'Is Monsieur d'Artagnan there?'

'Yes, madame, in your oratory. He is waiting till your majesty is ready.'

'I am. Go and tell Laporte to wake and dress the king, and then pass on to the Maréchal de Villeroy and summon him to me.'

Bernouin bowed and retired.

The queen entered her oratory, which was lighted by a single lamp of Venetian crystal, She saw D'Artagnan, who stood expecting her.

'Is it you?' she said.

'Yes, madame.'

'Are you ready?'

'I am.'

'And his eminence, the cardinal?'

'Has got off without any accident. He is awaiting your majesty at Cours la Reine.'

'But in what carriage do we start?'

'I have provided for everything; a carriage below is waiting for your majesty.'

'Let us go to the king.'

D'Artagnan bowed and followed the queen. The young Louis was already dressed, with the exception of his shoes and doublet; he had allowed himself to be dressed, in great astonishment, overwhelming Laporte with questions, who replied only in these words, 'Sire, it is by the queen's commands.'

The bedclothes were thrown back, exposing the king's bed linen, which was so worn that here and there holes could be seen. It was one of the results of Mazarin's niggardliness.

The queen entered and D'Artagnan remained at the door. As soon as the child perceived the queen he escaped from Laporte and ran to meet her. Anne then motioned to D'Artagnan to approach, and he obeyed.

'My son,' said Anne of Austria, pointing to the musketeer, calm, standing uncovered, 'here is Monsieur d'Artagnan, who is as brave as one of those ancient heroes of whom you like so much to hear from my women. Remember his name well and look at him well, that his face may not be forgotten, for this evening he is going to render us a great service.'

The young king looked at the officer with his large-formed eye, and repeated:

'Monsieur d'Artagnan.'

'That is it, my son.'

The young king slowly raised his little hand and held it out to the musketeer; the latter bent on his knee and kissed it.

'Monsieur d'Artagnan,' repeated Louis; 'very well, madame.'

At this moment they were startled by a noise as if a tumult were approaching.

'What is that?' exclaimed the queen.

'Oh, oh!' replied D'Artagnan, straining both at the same time his quick ear and his intelligent glance, 'it is the murmur of the populace in revolution.'

'We must fly,' said the queen.

'Your majesty has given me the control of this business; we had better wait and see what they want.'

'Monsieur d'Artagnan!'

'I will answer for everything.'

Nothing is so catching as confidence. The queen, full of energy and courage, was quickly alive to these two virtues in others.

'Do as you like,' she said, 'I rely upon you.'

'Will your majesty permit me to give orders in your name throughout this business?'

'Command, sir.'

'What do the people want this time?' demanded the king.

'We are about to ascertain, sire,' replied D'Artagnan, as he rapidly left the room.

The tumult continued to increase and seemed to surround the Palais Royal entirely. Cries were heard from the interior, of which they could not comprehend the sense. It was evident that there was clamor and sedition.

The king, half dressed, the queen and Laporte remained each in the same state and almost in the same place, where they were listening and waiting. Comminges, who was on guard that night at the Palais Royal, ran in. He had about two hundred men in the courtyards and stables, and he placed them at the queen's disposal.

'Well,' asked Anne of Austria, when D'Artagnan reappeared, 'what does it mean?'

'You are a hero, my friend,' said Mazarin, gazing at the musketeer with admiration.

D'Artagnan smiled.

'And I?' asked Mazarin, after a moment's silence.

'How? and you, my lord?'

'If I wish to leave?'

'That would be much more difficult.'

'Why so?'

'Your eminence might be recognised.'

'Even under this disguise?' asked Mazarin, raising a cloak which covered an arm-chair, upon which lay a complete dress for an officer, of pearl-gray and red, entirely embroidered with silver.

'If your eminence is disguised it will be almost easy.'

'Ah!' said Mazarin, breathing more freely.

'But it will be necessary for your eminence to do what the other day you declared you should have done in our place—cry, "Down with Mazarin!"'

'I will: "Down with Mazarin"'

'In French, in good French, my lord, take care of your accent; they killed six thousand Angevins in Sicily because they pronounced Italian badly. Take care that the French do not take their revenge on you for the Sicilian vespers.'

'I will do my best.'

'The streets are full of armed men,' continued D'Artagnan. 'Are you sure that no one is aware of the queen's project?'

Mazarin reflected.

'This affair would give a fine opportunity for a traitor, my lord; the chance of being attacked would be an excuse for everything.'

Mazarin shuddered, but he reflected that a man who had the least intention to betray would not warn first.

'And therefore,' added he, quietly, 'I have not confidence in every one; the proof of which is, that I have fixed upon you to escort me.'

'Shall you not go with the queen?'

'No,' replied Mazarin.

'Then you will start after the queen?'

'No,' said Mazarin again.

'Ah!' said D'Artagnan, who began to understand.

'A woman's caprice—you understand.'

'Yes, I understand perfectly,' said D'Artagnan.

'It was for this she summoned you this morning and that she told you to return at five o'clock.'

'Was it worth while to wish me to swear this morning that I would mention the appointment to no one?' muttered D'Artagnan. 'Oh, women! women! whether queens or not, they are always the same.'

'Do you disapprove of this journey, my dear M. d'Artagnan?' asked Mazarin, anxiously.

'I, my lord?' said D'Artagnan; 'why should I?'

'Because you shrug your shoulders.'

'It is a way I have of speaking to myself. I neither approve nor disapprove, my lord; I merely await your commands.'

'Good; it is you, accordingly, that I have pitched upon to conduct the king and the queen to Saint Germain.'

'Liar!' thought D'Artagnan.

'You see, therefore,' continued the cardinal, perceiving D'Artagnan's composure, 'that, as I have told you, the welfare of the state is placed in your hands.'

'Yes, my lord, and I feel the whole responsibility of such a charge.'

'You accept, however?'

'I always accept.'

'Do you think the thing possible?'

'Everything is possible.'

'Shall you be attacked on the road?'

'Probably.'

'And what will you do in that case?'

'I shall pass through those who attack me.'

'And suppose you cannot pass through them?'

'So much the worse for them; I shall pass over them.'

'And you will place the king and queen in safety also, at Saint Germain?'

'Yes.'

'On your life?'

'On my life.'

'It means, madame, that the report has spread that the queen has left the Palais Royal, carrying off the king, and the people ask to have proof to the contrary, or threaten to demolish the Palais Royal.'

'Oh, this time it is too much!' exclaimed the queen, 'and I will prove to them I have not left.'

D'Artagnan saw from the expression of the queen's face that she was about to issue some violent command. He approached her and said in a low voice:

'Has your majesty still confidence in me?'

This voice startled her. 'Yes, sir,' she replied, 'every confidence; speak.'

'Will the queen deign to follow my advice?'

'Speak.'

'Let your majesty dismiss M. de Comminges and desire him to shut himself up with his men in the guardhouse and in the stables.'

Comminges glanced at D'Artagnan with the envious look with which every courtier sees a new favourite spring up.

'You hear, Comminges?' said the queen.

D'Artagnan went up to him; with his usual quickness he caught the anxious glance.

'Monsieur de Comminges,' he said, 'pardon me; we both are servants of the queen, are we not? It is my turn to be of use to her; do not envy me this happiness.'

Comminges bowed and left.

'Come,' said D'Artagnan to himself, 'I have got one more enemy.'

'And now,' said the queen, addressing D'Artagnan, 'what is to be done? for you hear that, instead of becoming calmer, the noise increases.'

'Madame,' said D'Artagnan, 'the people want to see the king and they must see him.'

'What! *must* see him! Where—on the balcony?'

'Not at all, madame, but here, sleeping in his bed.'

'Oh, your majesty,' exclaimed Laporte, 'Monsieur d'Artagnan is right.'

The queen became thoughtful and smiled, like a woman to whom duplicity is no stranger.

'Without doubt,' she murmured.

'Monsieur Laporte,' said D'Artagnan, 'go and announce to the people through the grating that they are going to be satisfied and that in five minutes

they shall not only see the king, but they shall see him in bed; add that the king sleeps and that the queen begs that they will keep silence, so as not to awaken him.'

'But not every one; a deputation of two or four people.'

'Every one, madame.'

'But reflect, they will keep us here till daybreak.'

'It shall take but a quarter of an hour, I answer for everything, madame; believe me, I know the people; they are like a great child, who only wants humoring. Before the sleeping king they will be mute, gentle and timid as lambs.'

'Go, Laporte,' said the queen.

The young king approached his mother and said, 'Why do as these people ask?'

'It must be so, my son,' said Anne of Austria.

'But if they say, "it must be" to me, am I no longer king?'

The queen remained silent.

'Sire,' said D'Artagnan, 'will your majesty permit me to ask you a question?'

Louis XIV turned around, astonished that any one should dare to address him. But the queen pressed the child's hand.

'Yes, sir.' he said.

'Does your majesty remember, when playing in the park of Fontainebleau, or in the palace courts at Versailles, ever to have seen the sky grow suddenly dark and heard the sound of thunder?'

'Yes, certainly.'

'Well, then, this noise of thunder, however much your majesty may have wished to continue playing, has said, "go in, sire. You must do so."'

'Certainly, sir; but they tell me that the noise of thunder is the voice of God.'

'Well then, sire,' continued D'Artagnan, 'listen to the noise of the people; you will perceive that it resembles that of thunder.'

In truth at that moment a terrible murmur was wafted to them by the night breeze; then all at once it ceased.

'Hold, sire,' said D'Artagnan, 'they have just told the people that you are asleep; you see, you still are king.'

Chapter LI

The Flight

When D'Artagnan returned to the Palais Royal at five o'clock, it presented, in spite of the excitement which reigned in the town, a spectacle of the greatest rejoicing. Nor was that surprising. The queen had restored Broussel and Blancmesnil to the people and had therefore nothing to fear, since the people had nothing more just then to ask for. The return, also, of the conqueror of Lens was the pretext for giving a grand banquet. The princes and princesses were invited and their carriages had crowded the court since noon; then after dinner the queen was to have a play in her apartment. Anne of Austria had never appeared more brilliant than on that day—radiant with grace and wit. Mazarin disappeared as they rose from table. He found D'Artagnan waiting for him already at his post in the ante-room.

The cardinal advanced to him with a smile and taking him by the hand led him into his study.

'My dear M. d'Artagnan,' said the minister, sitting down, 'I am about to give you the greatest proof of confidence that a minister can give an officer.'

'I hope,' said D'Artagnan, bowing, 'that you give it, my lord, without hesitation and with the conviction that I am worthy of it.'

'More worthy than any one in Paris my dear friend; therefore I apply to you. We are about to leave this evening,' continued Mazarin. 'My dear M. d'Artagnan, the welfare of the state is deposited in your hands.' He paused.

'Explain yourself, my lord, I am listening.'

'The queen has resolved to make a little excursion with the king to Saint Germain.'

'Aha!' said D'Artagnan, 'that is to say, the queen wishes to leave Paris.'